Conclusion

Competition for favour and cooperation with Iran is emerging, with many zigs and zags as a new arena of the rivalry between India and China. What is at stake over the long term is the role of those two countries, China and India, in an emerging Asia. For China, a strong position in Southwest Asia via partnership with Iran could mesh with a system of friends and allies around the broader Indian Ocean littoral. China probably aspires to eventual primacy in the South Asian–Indian Ocean Region as a necessary basis for China's rise as a true global power comparable to the United States. Ambitious rising powers must first dominate their immediate regions before they attempt to operate as a global power. But partnership with Iran is dangerous and risky for China because of Tehran's deep conflicts with the United States.

India for its part, views the South Asia–Indian Ocean Region as its historic and civilisational sphere of influence and security zone within which its security needs must remain paramount. Two proud peoples and powerful rising states are trying to nudge the SA-IOR along their desired trajectories. Iran's role in this contest will be a significant variable. The review of this contest over the several preceding pages suggests that China has several advantages over India. These are listed in Figure 6.2.